

# Complete Beginner's Installation & Setup Guide

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## WorkForge – Freelance Marketplace Script (Upwork Clone)

Welcome! This guide is written in simple, non-technical language so that **anyone** can easily install, customize the branding (name, logo, favicon), configure the environment, and launch this script on any web hosting provider (cPanel, Hostinger, Namecheap, Bluehost, SiteGround, VPS, etc.).

 **Visual guide:** Prefer a clickable, illustrated manual? Open `documentation/index.html` in your browser — it includes the same steps with screenshots of the marketplace.

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## 1. What You Need Before Starting

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Make sure your web hosting provides:

- **PHP Version:** 8.2 or 8.3+
- **PHP Extensions:** `BCMath`, `Ctype`, `Fileinfo`, `JSON`, `Mbstring`, `OpenSSL`, `PDO`, `PDO_MySQL`, `Tokenizer`, `XML`, `GD` (*Standard on almost all cPanel / Hostinger accounts*)
- **MySQL / MariaDB:** Version 5.7+ or 8.0+
- **Domain Name:** e.g., `https://yourdomain.com`

## 2. How to Customize Name, Logo & Icons

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You can customize your website's name, brand colors, logo, and favicon before or after uploading:

## A. Changing the Website Name

1. Open the `.env` file in any text editor (Notepad, VS Code, TextEdit).
2. Change the `APP_NAME` line:

```
APP_NAME="YourMarketplaceName"
```

3. To change the text title in the navbar and footer:
  - Open [resources/views/layouts/app.blade.php](#)
  - Search for `WorkForge` and replace it with your brand name (e.g., `GigSphere` or `HireHub`).

## B. Changing the Website Logo

- **Main SVG Logo:** Replace [public/favicon.svg](#) with your SVG logo.
- **Main PNG / Image Logo:** Place your logo image in `public/images/logo.png`.
- In [resources/views/layouts/app.blade.php](#) (Line ~85), you can replace the `W` letter badge with an `<img>` tag:

```

```

## C. Changing the Favicon (Browser Tab Icon)

1. Prepare your icon in `.ico`, `.svg`, or `.png` format.
2. Replace the following files in the `public/` directory:
  - `public/favicon.ico`
  - `public/favicon.svg`
  - `public/apple-touch-icon.png`

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## 3. How to Configure Your Environment ( `.env` File)

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In the extracted folder, look for the file named `.env` (or copy `.env.example` and rename it to `.env`).

Open `.env` with a text editor and fill in your settings:

```
# =====
# 1. APPLICATION SETTINGS
# =====
APP_NAME="WorkForge"
APP_ENV=production
APP_KEY=base64:7vF8t1r8f9QWl6dD6Hjkl2mNpQrStUvWxYz12345678=
APP_DEBUG=false
APP_URL=https://yourdomain.com

# =====
# 2. DATABASE SETTINGS (From your Hosting cPanel)
# =====
DB_CONNECTION=mysql
DB_HOST=127.0.0.1
```

```

DB_PORT=3306
DB_DATABASE=yourhosting_dbname
DB_USERNAME=yourhosting_dbuser
DB_PASSWORD=yourhosting_dbpassword

# =====
# 3. SESSION & STORAGE
# =====
SESSION_DRIVER=database
QUEUE_CONNECTION=sync
FILESYSTEM_DISK=public

# =====
# 4. PAYMENT GATEWAY (Dodo Payments)
# =====
DODO_PAYMENTS_API_KEY=your_dodo_live_or_test_api_key
DODO_PAYMENTS_WEBHOOK_SECRET=your_dodo_webhook_secret
DODO_PAYMENTS_ENVIRONMENT=live # Use 'test_mode' for sandbox

# =====
# 5. EMAIL SETTINGS (SMTP)
# =====
MAIL_MAILER=smtp
MAIL_HOST=smtp.mailgun.org # or mail.yourdomain.com
MAIL_PORT=587
MAIL_USERNAME=your_smtp_username
MAIL_PASSWORD=your_smtp_password
MAIL_ENCRYPTION=tls
MAIL_FROM_ADDRESS="no-reply@yourdomain.com"
MAIL_FROM_NAME="${APP_NAME}"

```

 **Tip:** If you don't have an `APP_KEY`, you can generate one via terminal with `php artisan key:generate` or use the pre-filled key in the package.

## 4. How to Create a Database in Your Hosting

If using **cPanel**:

1. Log into your **cPanel** dashboard.
2. Under the **Databases** section, click **MySQL Databases** (or **MySQL Database Wizard**).
3. **Create Database:** Enter a name (e.g. `workforge`) → Click **Create Database**.
4. **Create User:** Enter a username (e.g. `dbuser`) and a secure password → Click **Create User**.
5. **Add User to Database:** Select the user and database you just created → Check **ALL PRIVILEGES** → Click **Make Changes**.
6. Copy the **Database Name**, **Database User**, and **Password** into your `.env` file ( `DB_DATABASE`, `DB_USERNAME`, `DB_PASSWORD` ).

## 5. Uploading the Files to Your Hosting

## Method A: Upload via cPanel File Manager (Recommended)

1. Zip the files on your computer if they aren't already zipped.
2. In cPanel, click **File Manager**.
3. Navigate to `public_html` (or your subdomain directory).
4. Click **Upload** and upload the zip file.
5. Right-click the uploaded zip file → select **Extract**.
6. Make sure the files are extracted directly inside `public_html`.

⚠ **Important for Root Routing on Shared Hosting:** This script is already configured with an optimized root `.htaccess` file so that your visitors are automatically routed to the public directory securely without showing `/public/` in the URL!

## Method B: Upload via FTP (FileZilla)

1. Open FileZilla (or Cyberduck).
2. Enter your FTP Host, Username, Password, and Port (21).
3. Open `public_html` on the remote server.
4. Drag and drop all project files from your computer into `public_html`.

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## 6. Importing Database & Running Migrations

You have two simple ways to set up the database tables:

### Option 1: Via cPanel phpMyAdmin (Easiest for Non-Technical Users)

1. In cPanel, click **phpMyAdmin**.
2. Click on your database name on the left sidebar.
3. Click the **Import** tab at the top.
4. Click **Choose File** and select the file `database/schema.sql` (or `database/database.sqlite` converted).
5. Click **Import / Go** at the bottom.

### Option 2: Via the Built-in Web Installer (1-Click, Recommended)

- **If you have SSH Terminal:** Run:

```
php artisan migrate:fresh --seed --force
```

- **If you don't have SSH Terminal:** Simply visit the built-in setup URL in your browser:

```
https://yourdomain.com/installer.php?secret=workforge2026
```

*(This automatically creates ALL database tables, categories, skills, sample jobs, and demo users in one click. When you see the green "Setup completed successfully!" message, your marketplace is ready.)*

- **After setup, delete the `installer.php` file** from the `public/` folder so the setup wizard can't be opened again.

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## 7. Setting Up Public Storage for Images

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To make sure profile avatars, job attachments, and portfolio images load quickly:

- **Via SSH / Terminal:**

```
php artisan storage:link
```

- **Via cPanel File Manager (without SSH):**

1. Open `public_html/public/`
2. If a shortcut named `storage` is not present, upload this tiny one-line PHP helper as `public_html/public/storage-link.php`, open `https://yourdomain.com/storage-link.php` in your browser, then **delete the helper file**:

```
<?php symlink('../storage/app/public', __DIR__ . '/storage'); echo 'Storage link created!';
```

3. Note: the built-in `installer.php` also tries to create this link automatically during setup.

- **File Permissions:** Ensure the following folders have **775** or **755** write permissions:
  - `storage/`
  - `storage/app/public/`
  - `storage/app/public/avatars/`
  - `bootstrap/cache/`

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## 8. Configuring Email & Payment Gateways

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### Setting Up Dodo Payments (Direct Escrow & Global Wire)

1. Sign up at [dodopayments.com](https://dodopayments.com).
2. In your Dodo Dashboard, go to **Developer Settings** → **API Keys**.
3. Copy your API Key and paste it into `.env` :

```
DODO_PAYMENTS_API_KEY=your_dodo_api_key_here
```

4. Set your Webhook URL in Dodo Payments Dashboard to:

```
https://yourdomain.com/payments/dodo/webhook
```

### Setting Up SMTP Email (for notifications & password reset)

Fill in your email hosting details in `.env` :

```
MAIL_MAILER=smtp
MAIL_HOST=mail.yourdomain.com
MAIL_PORT=465
MAIL_USERNAME=support@yourdomain.com
MAIL_PASSWORD=YourEmailPassword
MAIL_ENCRYPTION=ssl
MAIL_FROM_ADDRESS="support@yourdomain.com"
MAIL_FROM_NAME="WorkForge Marketplace"
```

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## 9. Default Admin & Demo Logins

After installation, the system comes with ready-to-test demo accounts:

| Role               | Email                | Password | Quick 1-Click Login                                                                                       |
|--------------------|----------------------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Super Admin</b> | admin@upwork.test    | password | <a href="https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/admin">https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/admin</a>           |
| <b>Client</b>      | client@upwork.test   | password | <a href="https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/client">https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/client</a>         |
| <b>Freelancer</b>  | alex.dev@upwork.test | password | <a href="https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/freelancer">https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/freelancer</a> |

### Accessing the Super Admin Panel

Visit: <https://yourdomain.com/admin/dashboard>

From the Super Admin panel, you can:

- Moderate and approve/suspend users and freelancers.
- Moderate job listings and categories.
- Review and release escrow contracts and milestones.
- Review and approve withdrawal payout requests.
- Resolve client-freelancer disputes.

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## 10. Troubleshooting & Common Questions

**Q1: I see a "500 Internal Server Error" after uploading.**

- **Fix:** Check that your `.env` file exists and has correct database credentials. Make sure the folder `storage/` and `bootstrap/cache/` have **775** write permissions.

**Q2: Uploaded avatar images or photos show broken images.**

- **Fix:** Make sure you ran `php artisan storage:link` or connected `public/storage` to `storage/app/public`.

**Q3: How do I disable the "Demo Environment Quick Switcher" bar at the top?**

- **Fix:** In [resources/views/layouts/app.blade.php](#), look for lines 61–75 ( `<!-- Quick Role Switcher Banner -->` ) and delete or comment out that block when you are ready to go live!

#### Q4: How do I clear cache after editing files?

- In terminal:

```
php artisan view:clear  
php artisan config:clear  
php artisan cache:clear
```

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## 11. Support & Contact

Need help with installation, customization, or anything else? We're here for you!

- **Chat on WhatsApp:** [+92 345 9347900](https://wa.me/923459347900) — tap the link to start a WhatsApp chat (or add this number to your contacts and message us).
- **Email:** [um.waqas.khan@gmail.com](mailto:um.waqas.khan@gmail.com)

Please include a short description of your issue and, if possible, a screenshot so we can help you faster.

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### **Congratulations!**

Your marketplace is now live, fully branded, and ready to accept clients, freelancers, and payments!